

Disruptive Critters

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1 DESCRIPTION OF ARTWORK

Disruptive Critters is a playable interactive audiovisual installation designed to augment live multimedia sound art performances by Duckworth and Hullick (Duckworth Hullick Duo). At a time when artificial intelligence continues to advance, Disruptive Critters provides audiences with a humorous and playful exploration of future creativity and digital disruption through the vocalized human performative possibilities of autonomous computer-generated critters.

Disruptive Critters is developed as a speculative prototype sonic instrument with a focus on human vocal sounds that provides a critical perspective on the prevalence and potential of machine learning in disrupting creative processes. Through a critical and conceptual design lens, Disruptive Critters embodies the artists commentary around their apprehensions of engaging and communicating with, and through, unpredictable and complex evolving autonomous systems that give rise to uncertainty. The work playfully manifests these concerns in a simple speculative trajectory that references a fictional Pre-Cambrian time of sonic digital life that emerges and thrives in a seemingly uncontrolled and unconstrained manner that mischievously disrupt the performative actions and intentions of their human creators.

A multi-touch tabletop console invites the audience to construct their own immersive visceral experiences by triggering sound generating entities, or Critters, from a graphical menu. The Critters each have their own unique animated visual identity and vocal repertoire of abstract utterances. Players can build layered compositions of Critters vocally expressed from a palette of human emotions of joy, sadness, disgust, pleasure, surprise, and anger. Their autonomous nature means that players never know what to expect, leading to a sense of anticipation, excitement, and anxiety during live performances. The Critters become co-performers seemingly striving to communicate with players and with each other in unpredictable ways. The Critters appear to have their own agenda, gradually increasing in sonic complexity and evolving from one animated form



to another over time to create unexpected combinatorial sounds that can surprise and delight.

Players are immersed in a responsive, interactive world where the virtual critters seemingly come alive, teem and flock, collide and collude, evolve and devolve in various forms of sonic mischief that is ambiguous, surprising, amusing, and at times profoundly melodic. Through their unpredictable behaviour and unique vocal ranges, Disruptive Critters offers a new perspective on the relationship between human creativity and technology that is both unlimited and uncharted. The result is a one-of-a-kind digital instrument that challenges traditional notions of sounds art and offers an alternate perspective on the possibilities of digital disruption afforded by computational systems that transforms the gallery into an engaging and lively performance area.

The Disruptive Critters installation is designed to enable attendees to freely play, explore and experiment with the interface. There is no time limit to complete the experience. The interface is intuitive to use and requires little instruction to operate. The interface consists of a 42-inch multi-touch tabletop display; a graphical menu of six sound generating Critters positioned at either end of the display that the player can select. The six Critter types (or strains) are conceived as an ecology of evolving sonic entities. The strains are called (i) Pixel, (ii) Line, (iii) Spin, (iv) Flip, (v) Shape, and (vi) Cubic (see Fig.1 and Fig.2). A player simply touches to select a Critter type from the menu and drags to place and position in the scene. The audio generated by the Critter is spatialized based on its location in the scene. Once placed in the scene players can reposition the Critter by dragging, delete by pressing and holding over the Critter, and increase/decrease volume by pinching the Critter. The Critters can evolve in graphic and sonic complexity. For example, the Pixel Critter, which is visually represented by a dot, can transition, and stretch into a Line Critter triggering more complex sounds over

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time. Players can drag and drop evolve and devolve buttons over a Critter to trigger its evolution or devolution to the next strain. Players can also select from two distinct datasets of recorded vocals by artists James Hullick and Justine Anderson via a toggle button that changes the vocal range. The scene resets overtime when no interaction is detected and auto generates new Critter compositions. Subsequent interactions will reset the scene.

2 PROJECT URL

<https://jolted.art/disruptive-critters/>